



IN BRIEF

WOMEN OF THE WEST

While the Homestead Act and associated laws gave women in the US opportunities, western expansion forced Native Americans off their lands and onto reserves.

1800

- **1830** Andrew Jackson passes the Indian Removal Act, removing eastern Native American nations to lands west of the Mississippi River.
- **1841** The Prevention Act allows settlers to claim land before purchasing it.
- **1848** The gold rush occurs in California, leading to the removal of Native American nations living in the lands needed for mining towns.
- **1849** Andrew Johnson introduces a homestead bill to provide 160 acres of free land to any man who proved he could "improve it."
- **1850** The Donation Land Claim Act gives 640 acres to couples and 320 acres to individuals provided that they are over 18, white citizens, and promise to live on it for four years.
- **1862** President Lincoln passes the Homestead Act; women applying for land under their own name are eligible.
- **1863** Mary Meyer, who had been living on her land in Nebraska since 1860, becomes the first woman to file a homestead claim—less than three weeks after the first male claim.
- **1864** The US cavalry murders at least 150 Cheyenne and Arapaho people—mostly women, children, and the elderly—in the Sand Creek Massacre, Colorado.
- **1871** A total of 144 Apache people, mostly women and children, are slaughtered by the Committee of Public Safety outside Camp Grant Arizona where they have been granted asylum.
- **1890** Considered the last battle of the Plains Wars, US troops kill at least 150 unarmed men, women, and children in the Wounded Knee Massacre, South Dakota.

◀ **A MORMON AND HIS WIVES STAND IN FRONT OF THEIR HOMESTEAD IN GREAT SALT LAKE VALLEY, 1869.**

